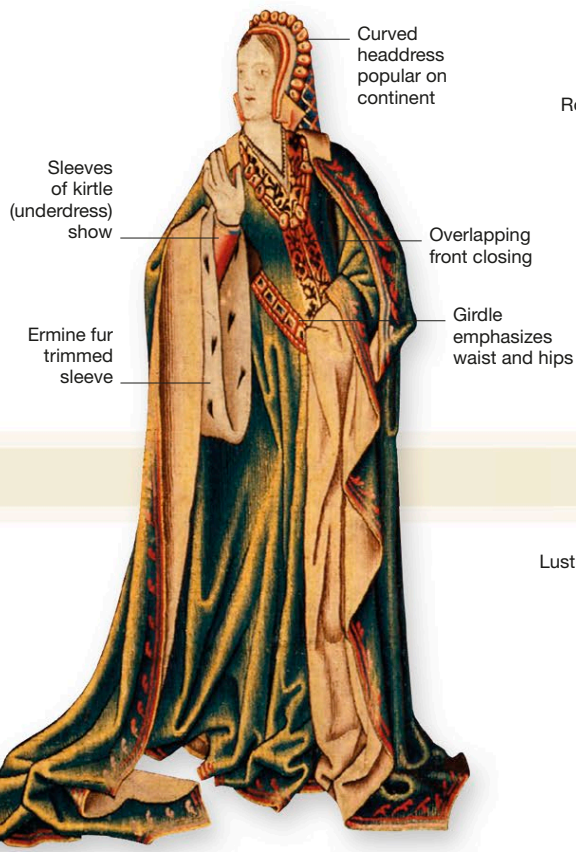
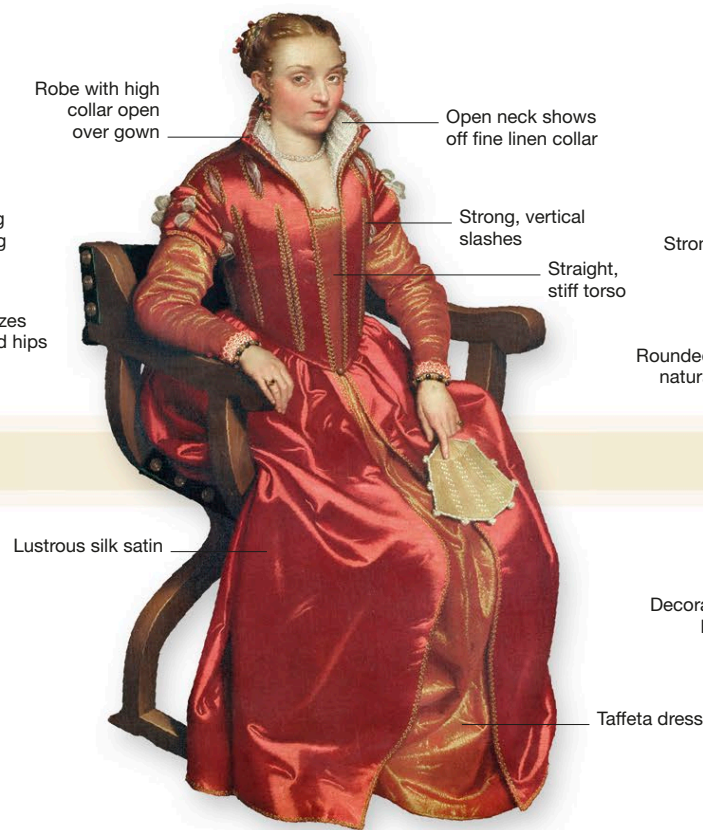
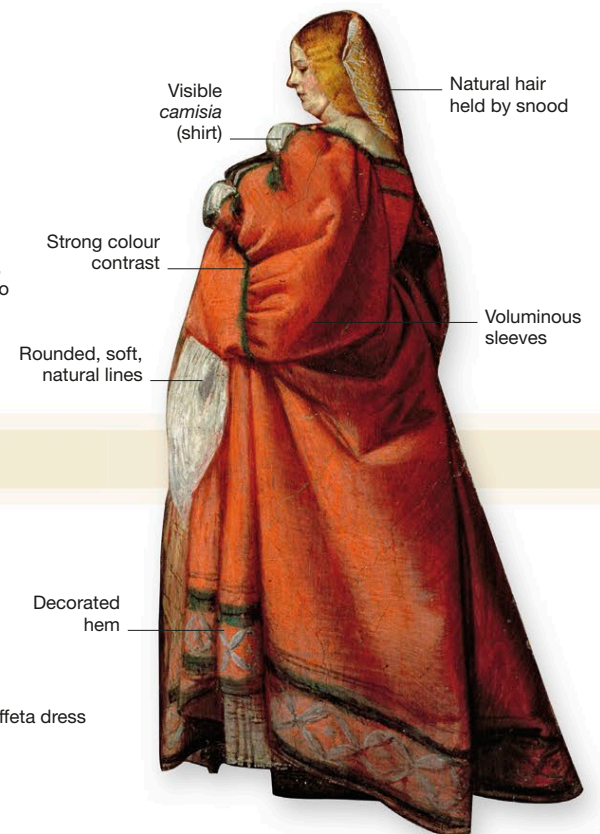




Softly draped dress This Flemish dress from c.1500 shows the soft, early version of a style that became rigid in form as the century progressed. The torso is natural in shape, and the sleeve cuffs are large. The woman's long mantle (cloak) covers her trailing skirts.



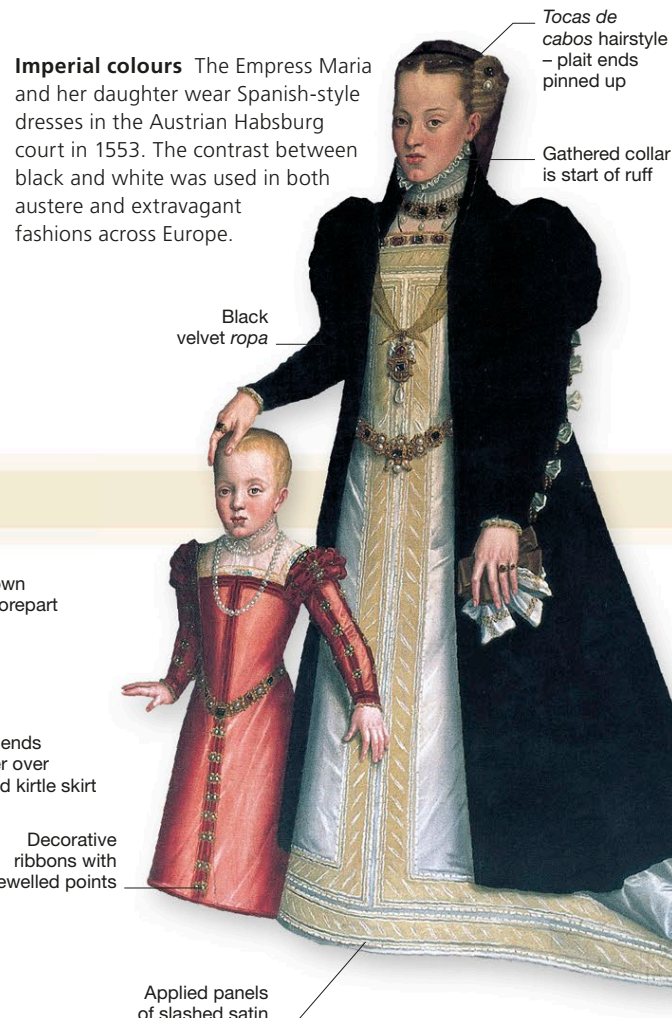
Satin and taffeta The smooth, tight bodice contrasts with the sumptuous, light-catching folds of this Italian dress from c.1555. The red overgown's short sleeves have fine silk puffs between the panes of fabric.



Gown with large sleeves Even without extra reinforcement, tightly woven silks had a stiffness and body that gave an angular bulk, here painted by Venetian artist Titian.



Royal splendour In the 1550s Queen Mary I continued to wear the English court styles popular during her father's reign, unlike her more fashionable sister, Elizabeth. Women could cover their neck and bust with separate partlets in fine or heavy fabrics.



LINEN SHIRTS



Beneath every elaborate gown a linen undergarment was worn next to the skin. It was known by many names: English smock, shift, or shirt; French *chemise*; Italian *camisia*; Spanish *camisa*; and German *hemd*. This was an essential layer because linen could be washed and it protected outer garments (which were never washed) from the body. When clothing started to reveal this layer, emphasis on the linen quality and delicate embroidery around the neck and cuffs increased. Sleeves became bigger to create abundant billows emerging from gowns.